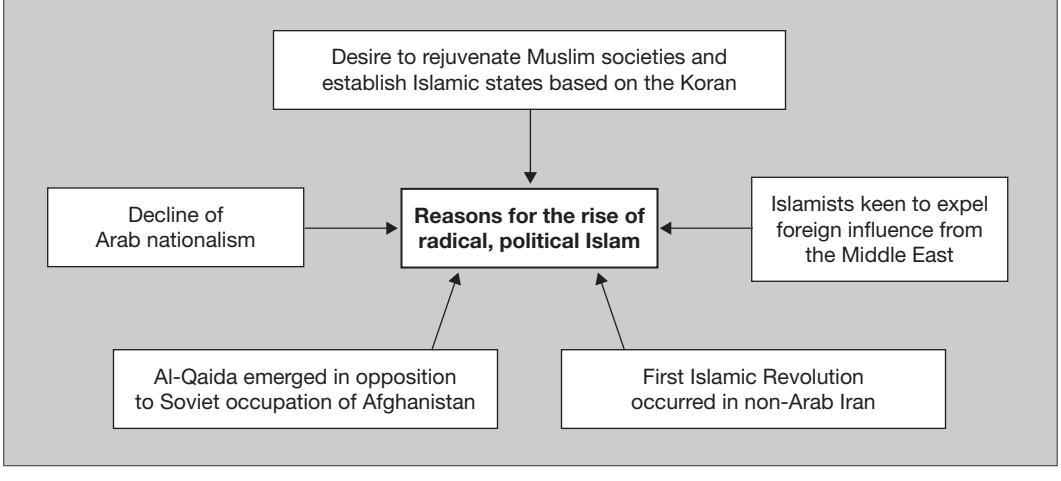
During the war in Afghanistan, the 'Arab Afghans' had received huge support from the US and Saudi governments but this alliance was shattered by the US-led attack on Iraq after the invasion of Kuwait in 1990–1. The 'Arab Afghans' and other Islamists were alarmed that the Saudi government had invited US troops into Saudi Arabia. They were horrified to see 'the forces of unbelievers occupy Islamic soil'. They thought the presence of US forces, in the land of the Prophet Muhammad, defiled the holy shrines of Mecca and Medina and was an insult to Muslims everywhere. In the eyes of Osama Bin Laden, the Saudi authorities had forfeited their claim to protect Islam. He branded the Saudi rulers as renegades from Islam. In 1992, he left Saudi Arabia for the Sudan and, two years later, the Saudi authorities deprived him of his Saudi nationality so that he became stateless.

Key dates

Iraqi invasion of Kuwait: 1990

US troops arrived in Saudi Arabia: 1990–1

Summary diagram: The rise of political Islam



2 | Al-Qaida and the Globalisation of Terror

Key question
How and why did al-Qaida gain support in the 1990s?

In 1996 Bin Laden returned to Afghanistan where he was sheltered by the **Taliban** movement. He used his wealth to revive al-Qaida and build 'a *jihad* camp for the world'. He was joined in Afghanistan by Ayman al-Zawahari, often described (since then) as 'number two' to Bin Laden. Al-Zawahari was an Egyptian, trained as a doctor, with many years of experience in the struggle of Islamic radicals against the Egyptian government. He brought with him networks of Egyptian activists, hardened by years of struggle in Egypt, into the new organisation now called al-Qaida.

In the mid-1990s, the failure of the so-called 'peace process' between Israel and the Palestinians gave a further spur to the development of radical Islam, especially as there was no progress in gaining Jerusalem for the Palestinians or any recognition of

Key term

Taliban
An Islamic movement, whose leaders were drawn from the former *mujahideen*, which took control of the Afghan government in 1996.